shared their food. The auto rickshaw driver took us to our hotel – accepting whatever meagre spare change we had. The Khadim[3] at the Ajmer dargah paid for our lunch. Even those seeking alms gave their blessings not expecting anything in return for everyone understood that cash was scarce. At Pushkar,[4] the catastrophic impact of demonetization was visible on the distressed faces all around us. Villagers, for whom this was a major annual income-generating event, sat resignedly waiting in vain for buyers. There were tourists aplenty, but no one had money that they could spend and everyone was spending long frustrating hours in ATM queues instead of at the fair.

On return to Delhi, we had dinner with a family friend who ran a successful brass export business from Moradabad. He employed skilled artisans on daily wages, based on the export orders he received. In 2016, he had received good orders for the Christmas season, and had taken on 2,000 workers. That evening he told us that he had let most of them go, as he could not pay their wages. 'It's crazy,' he said. 'I have the orders, I have the workers, and I have money in the bank, but I can't pay my workers and so will not be able to fulfil my orders. This has happened twice before. Once during the Mandal riots,[5] when I suffered a loss of ₹8 crore, and the second time during the Babri Masjid riots,[6] when I suffered a loss of ₹12 crore. I don't know what my loss will be this time…'

In December, our domestic staff too experienced the effects of demonetization. Without claiming to have any premonition about demonetization, but simply to make payments more seamless, I have been, for a long while, paying salaries digitally on the first of each month to our household staff, directly into their accounts. Our old family retainer transfers part of his salary home also digitally, by standing instructions to his bank. And on the second of each month, his wife, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, makes the 15 km bus journey, from her village to the nearest bank ATM, to draw money for the family's monthly expenses. In December 2016, she had to make 15